mental pathology, and with the work effected by those specially engaged in the treatment of insanity, as well as by other physicians. M. Delasiauve sets forth as his reasons for producing his small monthly brochure, that the 'Annales Medico-Psychologiques' is a journal too exclusively addressed to specialists, and that consequently its valuable papers are lost to the bulk of the profession. It is his object, therefore, to bring together all that relates, directly or indirectly, to mental and cerebral disease; to present it in a practical form, excluding long disquisitions, and to seek the co-operation of physicians not specially occupied in the treatment of the insane.

In all respects M. Delasiauve's journal has a wider scope than that published under the direction of M. Baillarger, which is exclusively a clinical record of cases of insanity communicated by various physicians attached to the French asylums. The editor states that its object is to form such a collection of well-observed cases that in course of time a much more certain and more accurate knowledge of the pathology of mental disorder may be arrived at than we at present possess. Three fourths of the journal will always be occupied with the detail of original cases, and the remainder with clinical histories recorded in foreign journals or described in books of repute.

Thus, though these two new periodicals may compete for public support, they do so under a different form, and each, we hope, may succeed in establishing itself in public favour.

Kleptomania.

The injudicious defence of two lady thieves on the plea that they were subject to that form of mental unsoundness to which Mathey* and Marc have given the sounding title of kleptomania, has attracted public attention to this form of mental disease, and has given rise to a considerable amount of written and spoken nonsense upon the subject. Even "our facetious contemporary" has had his jests and his caricatures thereupon, and in the slang of the day a burglar has become a kleptomaniac, and a prison a kleptomaniac hospital. Alienist physicians have of course received their full share of sarcastic remarks, as theorisers not over-wise nor over-useful to society, who would willingly provide for every crime a decent veil, by referring it to some strange form of mental disease. Now there is such a thing as theft which is the result of mental disease; and also, let us boldly avow our conviction, though we write within the precincts

* 'Récherches nouvelles sur les maladies de l'esprit.'

'Kleptomania', The Journal of Mental Science, vol. 8 (July 1862), p. 262 · Scan: Wellcome Library / Internet Archive · Reproduction

Englishwoman of the present day to spend no inconsiderable portion of her time in passing from shop to emporium, from haberdashery store to magazin de mode, in the discharge of that new and peculiar duty of life called 'shopping.' Can we be surprised that when the means fail to gratify the desires thus stimulated and thus tempted, that in some few instances the desire of the eye should prove too strong for the moral sense? It is painful and humiliating if these things are so, but it is not wonderful that they should be so; and on the whole we can find more pity for the poor woman who purloins a piece of lace, without which she thinks she will be absolutely not fit to be seen, than for the smirking fellow who has caught her in his haberdashery trap by lying advertisements that he sells for almost next to nothing the very articles she so covets in her desire to make her person agreeable and attractive. The fair thieves whom it would be more true than gallant to consider as an elder kind of children, if pity does not allow them to go scathless, when they steal the gewgaws in which their hearts delight, are punished with crushing and ruinous infamy, to escape from which the imputation of madness has sometimes been considered a welcome refuge.

But what is true kleptomania? Monomania du vol? Dieb-trieb? Real stealing insanity? There is a good deal of scattered information on the subject, and yet much remains to be gathered before we understand it well. We appear yet to have scarcely got beyond that early stage in a scientific inquiry which gives us a large generalisation. We have found that some people altogether or partially insane, are incorrigible thieves, and we have generalised the fact into the formation of a class of the insane, characterised by this tendency. But if we carefully examine the cases in the category thus formed, we find that they differ essentially from each other, and upon this analytic stage, which is the wider and more important part of the inquiry, psychological writers have scarcely entered. The material for examination is yet scanty, and in this absence of sufficient data these observations are made rather as suggestions of the method of inquiry, than as presenting anything like a satisfactory explanation. Theft is sometimes one of the earliest symptoms of mental disease, and if it were to be so decidedly the earliest symptom that no other indication of insanity existed, it would, of course, be extremely difficult to diagnose the character of the theft as of pathological nature. If it should happen to be the only symptom with which the physician is acquainted, he must necessarily suspend his judgment, for it is not by the perception of one attribute that one thing, even of the most simple character, can be recognised from another, and in matters of complicated science this is still less possible. A man may at night see an object which he remarks to have a round shape, but in the absence of sufficient light he cannot tell whether it is a disk or a sphere, much less can he tell if it is an

'Kleptomania', The Journal of Mental Science, vol. 8 (July 1862), p. 266 — on 'that new and peculiar duty of life called shopping' · Reproduction